will have. Like that, each according to their size. If people are able to earn on their own, save on their own, have some property of their own, that itself lifts them from where they are to the next level. It is that kind of targeted approach which can help remove inequality and which is also recognised by people who have looked at multidimensional poverty. Around 25 crore people have been pulled up from extreme poverty. Garibi Hatao didn't do that in 50 years.

Q. The Congress disagrees.

Inequality is the kind of debate Congress loves to have because they are anti-wealth creation. Do you think throwing that one lakh rupees, as the Congress promises, will meet a person's medical requirements, of education, of having a house or of getting drinking water in the house, or of getting cooking gas. It clearly shows the mentality of the Congress. Throw money at poverty and poverty will go away. That's why they also use this expression, "I have a magic wand with which I can remove poverty". You should have told your grandmother, even as a *bachcha* (child), that this is a magic wand but that you should use it, *Indiramma*, to remove poverty! These are very irresponsible ways of creating an illusion about how simple the problem is.

Q. Coming to private investment, are you disappointed that despite the government's actions, including reducing corporate tax, it remains sluggish? That corporates have not returned to the economy the profits that they have gained?

About the point whether they have returned to the economy, I think they have done it in the form of giving better dividends to their own shareholders. Most are not individually owned companies. There are small investors who put money in them who are also sitting and waiting for that golden day when they will get that money. So, dividends have gone to private, small investors as well. Second, they have paid tax. They have paid the banks back. So, your banks' health has been restored. It's not as if they have really not done much with it. But equally, I would also want our attention to go towards the investments that are happening in the newer areas, those who are investing in electric vehicles, setting up wind and solar parks. Then, in today's India, whether it's government bonds, or commercial borrowings, people find markets in India with money available for anybody to borrow from. The expression "crowding in" is actually happening now. Private money is coming into the markets. Companies are able to borrow from it. Government borrowing from the market has not put them out.

Q. So are you satisfied with the private investment that is coming in?

I would want it to be even more. There are newer areas. Renewable energy, API, medicines, large generic drug manufacturing are expanding in India. Look at the way API or active pharmaceutical ingredients are coming back into India. India was a leader in API at least 30 years ago. Gradually, we lost to predatory pricing from China. Today, government policy has made it attractive for companies to come back and set up API-producing units. And they are very high investment units, because API production involves a lot of processes that can pollute. To handle that pollution, they have to invest in pollution treatment plants and so on. Government is not setting up API units, the private sector is setting them up.



"Any amount of effort to contain inflation, because of the nature of the goods that come into the market and that make it to the poor man's *thali*, will always be inadequate"

Q. Although we saw the landmark sale of Air India, a few other disinvestment announcements remain pending. What are the reasons and will they be taken up if your government is re-elected?

The cabinet has already given a list of items where disinvestment was approved. If we have not completed the disinvestment of those for which approval has been obtained from the cabinet, it's not as if we've left them there languishing. The valuation of such public sector companies has increased manifold. In fact, the lowest increase in valuation is 150 per cent. Some have even crossed a 1,000-fold increase in